

COLLECTOR'S ILLUSTRATED FAMILY & LEADERSHIP FABLES

ZINAIDA JUPITER

THE FOX AND THE CRANE

A Classic Folk Fable Retold
with a Smart Boundaries Lesson for Children
and a Game-Theory Negotiation Matrix for Adults

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"A Wise Story for the Child • A Strategic Decision for the Leader"

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Set in the classic Bilibin and Folio Society bookmaking canon, Book II pairs the timeless fable of rigged hospitality with an invention challenge for children (pp. 8–9) and Robert Axelrod's Tit-for-Tat strategic matrix for leaders (pp. 10–11).

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❖ A Word to the Reader ❖

Dear Reader! While Book I ("The Crane and the Heron") explored how two sincere allies get trapped by their own pride, "The Fox and the Crane" tackles the opposite challenge: what to do when someone masks a rigged, one-sided deal behind honeyed compliments.

For a child, this fable teaches how to spot unfair play and set boundaries with calm wit rather than tears (**pp. 8–9**). For an executive or parent, it encodes the most famous strategy in Game Theory—how to neutralize manipulation politely by mirroring the counterpart's own rules (**pp. 10–11**).

With warmth to your family — Zinaida Jupiter,
Doctor of Business Administration (DBA)

THE FOX AND THE CRANE

A Classic Folk Fable in an Authorial Retelling

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“Flattering words cost nothing—true friendship is revealed by the dish set before the guest…”

Once upon a time, the Fox and the Crane struck up a great friendship. One bright morning, the Fox invited the Crane over for a festive dinner:

— Come visit me, dear neighbor! Oh, how warmly I shall welcome you!

The Crane arrived in his finest coat. Meanwhile, the Fox had cooked semolina porridge and smeared it in a paper-thin layer across a flat, shallow plate:

— Eat up, my dear guest! I cooked it myself, specially for you!



The Crane's narrow beak tapped against bare porcelain, while the sly hostess licked the flat plate clean.

The Crane leaned over the plate and tapped with his long, narrow beak—tap-tap! All in vain: not a single grain could he catch! Meanwhile, the Fox licked the dish with her broad tongue until she had eaten every bit of the porridge herself.

Licking her lips, the Fox gave a pretend sigh:
— Do forgive me, dear friend! I have nothing more to offer you!



Uttering not a single angry word, the Crane bowed politely and invited his hostess to dinner the next day.

The Crane neither argued nor complained. Standing tall, he bowed politely and replied:

— Thank you kindly for this much, dear hostess! Come dine with me tomorrow.

The next day the Fox arrived with a grand appetite. The Crane had prepared a fragrant cold soup—and poured it into a tall clay pitcher with a very narrow neck:

— Help yourself, dear guest! Truly, I have nothing else to offer!



The Fox circled the tall clay pitcher and licked its outside, while the Crane dined calmly with his long beak.

Round and round the pitcher circled the Fox: she tried to squeeze her muzzle in, sniffed the savory broth, and licked the clay neck—yet her head would not fit inside!

Meanwhile, the Crane stood calmly on his long legs, dipping his slender beak down the narrow neck until he had finished every drop himself.



Home trudged the Fox empty-handed: whoever sets a shallow plate for a friend will soon face a narrow pitcher.

Fury seized the Fox! She had expected to feast for a whole week, yet she walked home hungry and outsmarted.

As you call into the woods, so the echo answers! And from that day on, the friendship between the Fox and the Crane was over.

SMART BOUNDARIES & WIT LESSON FOR CHILDREN

The Secret of the Feast: Revenge or a Fair Mirror?

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Why the Crane Didn't Shout:

Arguing with a trickster never works—they just laugh. What cures a trickster is **calmly letting them experience their own rules**.

❖ Three Brainteasers to Debate Together:

I. Fairness on Trial: Was the Crane being mean when he served soup in a narrow pitcher? What is the difference between someone who tricks a guest first, and someone who simply holds up a mirror?

II. Why Did the Fox Get Mad: The Crane never called the Fox names—he repeated her exact words back to her! Why did the Fox storm off angry instead of laughing at her own trick and apologizing?

III. Day Three of the Story: Suppose the Fox and the Crane met on the forest path on Wednesday morning. What would the Fox need to bring in her paws for the Crane to trust her again?

❧ The "Crane's Smile" Move (When Someone Sets Up a One-Sided Game):

When a friend sounds super sweet but sets up rules where only they get a turn—don't cry or grab things by force. Smile and flip the mirror:

"Aha, that's like porridge smeared on a flat plate for the Crane! Let's switch turns every ten minutes so we both get to play!"

TRICK DETECTIVE & INVENTION CHALLENGE

Spot the "Flat Plate" & Invent a Fair Table!

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❖ Detective: "Sweet Words, Shallow Plate!"

See how the "Fox's Plate" shows up in everyday life—and how the Crane flips it with wit:

Trick 1. **"The Broken Controller":** *"Come play at my house! My second controller is broken, so I'll play all afternoon and you can watch me!"* → **Crane's Flip:** set a 10-minute timer and trade turns!

Trick 2. **"The Flattering Cleanup":** *"You're the best organizer in the world! Why don't you clean up all the blocks while I supervise?"* → **Crane's Flip:** you take the left half of the rug, I'll take the right!

★ **Inventor's Challenge:** Can you design **one special dish (or table setup)** that lets both a wide-tongued Fox and a long-beaked Crane eat comfortably at the same time?

❧ Inventor's Blueprint: A Dish for Both Fox and Crane ❧

Sketch your invention here (for example: a dual-chamber bowl or a matched pitcher-and-bowl table):

- ❖ **Smart Rule 1:** True friendship is measured by fair sharing, not just sweet compliments.
- ❖ **Smart Rule 2:** A true host serves the guest in a dish that fits the guest!

NEGOTIATION DECISION MATRIX • DOCTOR OF BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION (DBA)

The "Plate & Pitcher" Matrix: 4 Deal Models

The Fable's Core Trap: a counterpart showers you with praise ("my dearest partner!") while structuring the contract so only they can extract value. Let's map the 4 responses across **Axes Y and X**:

❖ DECISION MATRIX: FLATTERING WORDS VS. REAL DEAL TERMS ❖

LOW • AXIS Y: BOUNDARY DEFENSE • HIGH →

High Pushback + Loss of Poise (Top-Left)

2. "Flipping the Table"

Losing your temper and accusing the Fox of malice. Trap: because she was publicly polite, your outburst makes you look unstable.

★ WINNING ANSWER (TOP-RIGHT CORNER)

4. "The Mirror Pitcher" (Leader)

Impeccable courtesy + strict symmetry. You calmly mirror the counterpart's terms: an honest partner adapts the bowl; a trickster walks away.

Fear of Awkwardness + Loss (Bottom-Left)

1. "The Naive Guest"

Pecking politely at bare porcelain and absorbing one-sided costs because you feel awkward pushing back against a smiling host.

Short-Term Trick + Ruined Trust (Bottom-Right)

3. "The Fox's Flat Plate"

Rigging contract terms behind warm rhetoric. Wins one free lunch at the cost of permanently destroying long-term market trust.

◄ Low (Rigged) AXIS X: SYMMETRY OF RULES High (Equal Table) ►

❧ Reading the 4 Quadrants in Plain Executive Terms:

Quadrant 1 ("The Naive Guest"): Mistaking warm small talk for a fair deal and signing asymmetric obligations out of politeness.

Quadrant 2 ("Flipping the Table"): Reacting to subtle manipulation with public anger—handing the manipulator an easy political victory.

Quadrant 3 ("The Fox's Flat Plate"): Malicious compliance ("the data is technically on the table")—toxic short-termism that kills alliances.

★ Quadrant 4 ("The Mirror Pitcher" — Top-Right): Keeping a warm smile while making every obligation 100% bilateral.

ROBERT AXELROD'S GAME THEORY • EXECUTIVE PLAYBOOK

The "Tit-for-Tat" Protocol & the "Mute Test"

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Move 1. The "Mute the Audio, Inspect the Plate" Filter: In any negotiation, mentally press Mute on all flattery and promises of future synergy. Inspect only the geometry of the plate: who holds downside risk, cash flow control, and exit rights?

Move 2. Axelrod's Winner (Tit-for-Tat): In Robert Axelrod's famous Game Theory tournaments, the Crane's exact algorithm beat every complex strategy: 1) start cooperative; 2) mirror defection immediately without anger; 3) never reward a rigged plate twice.

Move 3. The "Symmetrical Clause" Counter-Move: Never argue about a Fox's motives—simply smile and make their rule apply equally to both sides:

The "Porridge on a Flat Plate" Ploy	Quadrant 1 Mistake (Naive Concession)	★ Quadrant 4 Move ("The Mirror Pitcher")
Asked to deliver a massive custom pilot for free "in exchange for future strategic volume"	Burn team bandwidth on verbal promises.	"Love the vision. We run phase one at standard fee, and credit 100% of that amount toward the annual contract upon signature."
A peer department praises collaboration, then dumps a 500-page raw CSV 10 minutes before the board call	Stay up all night cleaning their data silently.	"Thanks for sending the raw file! To include your section in the board deck, we need the 3-line summary table filled by 4:00 PM today."
A vendor or client inserts harsh penalties only on your side: "It's just standard legal boilerplate!"	Sign asymmetric liability to avoid friction.	"We're fine keeping that clause—let's simply make it bilateral so the exact same daily rate applies to delayed sign-offs or payments."

❖ **Deal Audit: Where are you currently being served a "flat plate" disguised as friendly partnership?**

❖ **Mature Leader's Formula:** A genuine partner readily accepts symmetrical terms; instant irritation at a mirror clause exposes a "Fox" in sixty seconds.

EXECUTIVE & FAMILY TAKEAWAY

Two Golden Keys of "The Fox and the Crane"

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From this classic fable of two neighbors, both child and leader carry away a sharp rule of wisdom:

❖ Key for the Child (6+)

1. Judge by the dish, not the flattery: a real friend shares fairly instead of just talking sweetly.

2. Answer tricks with calm wit: instead of crying or fighting, smile and propose equal turns!

★ Key for the Leader (DBA)

1. Run the "Mute Test": evaluate every partnership by the symmetry of concrete terms, not the warmth of compliments.

2. Set out a "Mirror Pitcher": calmly make any one-sided clause bilateral—the fastest test of good faith in business.

ILLUSTRATED LITERARY & EXECUTIVE EDITION • FAMILY READING (AGES 6+)

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THE FOX AND THE CRANE

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